resistance from Punjab's farming community, while also fanning the flames of the separatist movement. In 1985, the then SAD chief, Harchand Singh Longowal, was assassinated by pro-Khalistani militants after the crucial Rajiv-Longowal Accord with the Centre that had given in-principle consent to the construction of the canal. Then, in July 1990, Babbar Khalsa militant Balwinder Singh Jatana killed two government officials supervising the construction of the SYL canal at their office in Chandigarh, bringing the work to a halt in Punjab even as Haryana completed the project on its side.

THE OPPOSITION FEELS THAT BHAGWANT MANN'S LAW OFFICERS SHOULD HAVE CONVINCED THE SC BENCH TO REVIEW THE WATER SITUATION IN PUNJAB INSTEAD OF OPENING A WINDOW FOR A FRESH SURVEY THAT COULD RESULT IN AN ADVERSE RULING

In January 2002, the apex court—acting on Haryana's six-year-old plea—directed the then chief minister Parkash Singh Badal's SAD government to complete the Punjab leg of the canal within a year. But Badal refused to comply. His successor, Captain Amarinder Singh of the Congress, went a step further, passing the Punjab Termination of Agreement Act, 2004,

CERVICAL CANCER

A TOOL FOR EARLY DETECTION

By Jeemon Jacob

One woman dies of cervical cancer every eight minutes in India. The country also accounts for the highest number of cervical cancer cases in Asia (followed by China), according to a 2022 *Lancet* study. Despite this burden—and the fact that it is one of the most preventable of all cancers—action against cervical cancer has been slow in India. Now, a new AI-assisted screening tool developed by the Thiruvananthapuram-based Regional Cancer Centre (RCC), patented last year and all ready for use, has come as a genuine breakthrough for early detection.

Costing less than Rs 50 lakh, the screening tool, named 'CerviSCAN', will substantially cut down detection time for cervical cancers compared to the traditional Pap test. After cells are collected from the cervix using a traditional swab method, they are prepared for a smear on CerviSCAN using a specially developed technology, and then coloured in a unit with the self-explanatory name 'autostainer'. Compared to the two hours' scanning time in a conventional Pap test, cells can be scanned in just eight minutes on CerviSCAN. They are then analysed using AI-assisted technology, and a report indicating abnormality, if any, is received on the computer system. That the cells are studied in the 25 most relevant frames further ensures the accuracy of the computer report. Apart from the autostainer, the two other main components of the CerviSCAN system include a Kytospin (a special type of centrifuge) and a scanner unit.

"Compared to a cytotechnologist, who can analyse 30-40 Pap smears a day, CerviSCAN can analyse 30 times more without human errors. Computerised Pap smear testing is now available in some developed countries, but such devices cost crores of rupees," says Dr Rekha A. Nair, director of the RCC, Thiruvananthapuram. "Every year, the government spends over Rs 500 crore as subsidy for treatment of cervical cancer in India. CerviSCAN helps with early detection.... The device is cost-effective and will help India lead the WHO Cervical Cancer Elimination programme by 2030 among developing nations," she points out. CerviSCAN, she adds, will also help in mass screening programmes. That's particularly important in a country like India, where most cervical cancer cases are detected only in the later stages characterised by a regional



"COMPARED TO A CYTO-TECHNOLOGIST, WHO CAN ANALYSE 30-40 PAP SMEARS A DAY, CERVISCAN CAN ANALYSE 30 TIMES MORE"

DR REKHA A. NAIR
Director, Regional Cancer Centre, Thiruvananthapuram